Driven by growing consumer interest, he has expanded to six outlets and also launched a Korean food convenience store, K Friends, with three locations in Delhi-NCR and one in Guwahati.

Social media has accelerated the reach of Korean trends, bringing them to Indian consumers faster than ever. Indians now want the lifestyle products they see in K-Dramas—from beauty to fashion to stationery. Korean lifestyle brand Koja, for instance, has expanded to eight stores across India and is growing at 30–40 per cent year-on-year, according to founder and managing partner Bryan Tseda. "Initially, it was just K-culture fans, but the customer base has broadened. In metros, K-beauty drives sales, while in tier 2 and 3 cities, it's fashion and stationery," he says. One of Koja's hottest sellers? TirTir cushion foundation—a viral beauty product in Korea.

THE BUSINESS OF BEAUTY

If beauty is only skin-deep, Korea has shown the world how to perfect it. The global obsession with Korean 'glass skin'—that dewy, pore-free glow—owes to the flawless complexions of the K-Pop and K-Drama idols, as well as TikTok. The famed 10-step Korean skincare routine, focusing on gentle, preventive and long-term skin health over quick fixes, and the use of natural, local ingredients like ginseng, fermented beans and volcanic clay has found many takers among Gen Z. "I live for the glow and softness a Beauty of Joseon rice face mask gives my skin," says Sai Chikane.

India had its first brush with K-beauty in 2013, when South Korean cosmetics giant Amorepacific launched Innisfree, one of the first Korean skincare brands, in the country. It also educated consumers on the philosophy behind K-beauty, the ingredients and routines, says Mini Sood Banerjee, assistant director and marketing head, Amorepacific India. Social media and beauty influencers did the rest to help K-beauty gain rapid traction. Today, there are over 60 Korean beauty brands in India, including The Face Shop, Laneige, Etude, Cosrx and Sulwhasoo. Most of them entered the Indian market through offline retail and platforms such as Nykaa and Amazon. "K-beauty has evolved rapidly from a niche category to a major growth driver within the beauty portfolio, growing at an impressive 75 per cent year-over-year," says Siddharth Bhagat, director, Amazon Fashion and Beauty India. Skincare leads the category, with products like hydrating serums, sheet masks, lip sleeping masks and soothing creams flying off the shelves. Indian brands, too have jumped onto the K-beauty bandwagon. Actress Kareena Kapoor, in collaboration with Sugar Cosmetics, launched Quench Botanics in 2022, while Reliance Retail's beauty retailer Tira recently introduced Mixsoon.

With its rising popularity, K-beauty has seen significant growth in the past five years. According to market research and consulting company Grand View Research, the global K-beauty market was $91.99 billion in 2022 and is projected to grow at a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 9.3 per cent from 2023 to 2030. Though there are no specific numbers for India, the segment is certainly one of the fastest-growing in the Indian skincare space.

K-LINGO
FAB VOCAB

MAKNAE: A Korean word meaning 'the youngest member of a group or family'

BORAHAE: Literal translation: 'I Purple You'. Signifies the bond between the BTS band and their fanbase

NORAEBANG: Private song room you can rent for karaoke and sing like no one's watching

DAEBAK: One of Korea's most common slang words, meaning 'awesome' or 'cool'

HWAITING: A popular way for Koreans to cheer each other on, meaning 'You can do it!'

SEOUL MATES

The growing obsession with all things Korean has naturally led to an interest in visiting the country itself. The number of Indians travelling to Korea rose from 122,771 travellers in 2023 to 176,668 in 2024, a 44 per cent year-on-year growth. In just the first four months of this year, 60,000 Indian travellers have already visited Korea. That enthusiasm isn't waning despite the steep cost—a week-long trip to Korea can cost Rs 2.5-4 lakh per person. "Four to five years ago, travel to Korea was mostly for business, led by chaebol like Samsung and Hyundai in India, with most trips being two to three nights long," says Neeraj Singh Dev, executive vice president, Thomas Cook (India) & SOTC Travels. "Today, they last at least a week."

Myong Kil Yun, regional director, India & SAARC countries, Korea Tourism Organisation (KTO), also observes a growing trend in personalised or themed itineraries. "Due to the cultural affinity Indians now feel with Koreans, many Indian tourists express a desire to visit filming locations, try Korean skincare routines, or attend K-Pop concerts," he says. "This has resulted in more travellers opting for K-Drama tours or heritage-focused travel inspired by what they have seen on screen," he says. Younger travellers, in particular, are drawn to pop culture experiences like visiting the BTS bus stop in Jumunjin or exploring locations from K-series like *Goblin* and *Crash Landing on You*.

Korea is indeed having a prolonged moment in India. If America gave us burgers and the Hollywood film, the Italians pasta and pizza, China brought noodles and cheap consumer goods and Japan introduced us to anime and sushi, the Korean wave is broadening the Indian worldview in a myriad other ways. This is how you project soft power, and India can perhaps take a leaf out of the Korean playbook. ■

—with Shelly Anand